



Jargon Buster

Root Mean Square (RMS): The sustained power in Watts that an amplifier can output at any given time.

Peak Music Power Output (PMPO): It's the maximum power that an amplifier can output for a short period of time.

Frequency Response: It is the range of frequencies that the device is set to operate within.

Dolby Digital 5.1 (Dolby AC-3): Developed by Dolby, this system has five discrete sound channels, in addition to Low Frequency Effects (LFE) that are directed to the sub-woofer.

Dolby Pro Logic: An older standard, this packs in information for a centre and surround channel in the normal stereo channel. Essentially, there are no discrete left and right channels for the rear or surround speakers.

Dolby Pro Logic II: Audio encoded with Pro Logic II carries five channels of sound in a traditional two-channel stereo audio signal, which is then decoded back to five speakers using a Dolby Surround Pro Logic II decoder. This technology can be used on any console that does not support Dolby Digital 5.1. The advantages of using it in game applications include minimal latency, full frequency range, compatibility with existing cables and backwards compatibility with mono, stereo and legacy Dolby Surround Pro Logic equipment.

DTS: Short for Digital Theatre Systems, this is a standard invented by Steven Spielberg and made its debut in *Jurassic Park*. It uses a sampling frequency of 96 KHz with 24 bits allocated to each of

the six channels. Collector's edition DVD movies normally feature two soundtracks featuring both, Dolby 5.1, and DTS.

Dolby Digital EX and DTS ES: These are comparatively new standards that add an additional channel, which is the rear centre channel and is implemented in 6.1 speakers. Both the standards implement the rear channel somewhat similarly. For Dolby Digital EX, a special Dolby Pro Logic decoder is added to the surround channels creating a rear centre channel. This decoding method first came to light with the theatrical release of *Star Wars Episode 1*. For DTS ES, an additional rear centre channel is supplemented to the two surround channels.

Dolby Pro Logic IIx: This is a spanking new technology developed by Dolby Laboratories and is the first and only technology to process native stereo or 5.1 signals into 6.1 or 7.1 channel output. Different modes such as movie, music and game are available with this technology with the music mode featuring additional user controls such as Dolby centre width, Dolby panorama, and Dolby dimension.

THX: This is an abbreviation for Tomlinson Holman's eXperiment. It's not a surround sound standard but a seal of approval that is granted to audio equipment and theatres that meet its standards. This standard is further divided into THX Select (for installations upto 2000 cubic feet) and THX Ultra (2000-3000 cubic feet).

Sony Dynamic Digital Sound (SDDS): This proprietary Sony format provides up to eight channels of discrete sound. Sony designed this exclusively for motion picture theatres.

// This (Creative Megaworks 550) is a powerful PC sound station. If you like to listen to loud music, then this can handle about 500 W RMS output. Because of its steady and powerful bass, it does not give the clear picture of sound. Needs more pre-emphasis to increase the highs in the range of 3 KHz till 15 KHz to get clearer sound. Playing games and watching action movies on this will be a great experience. //

— NISSAR ALI CHIKATE

Ease of use

While most of the speakers were easy to set up, the Creative GD580 and the 5700D took a little longer as they had various input options, and we couldn't resist trying each one out. The Creative 5700D took the longest—it has a complicated decoder configuration. The other speakers were literally plug-and-play, and the average time taken per set was about 15 minutes—including unpacking the speakers from the box!

The Odyssey and the Typhoon definitely need to provide a remote. The Artis has bass and rear controls on the back, but the remote feels like it would shatter if you dropped it. The Megaworks remote remembers settings if you leave the speaker on, and leave the remote on standby. However, the settings are reset if you power down the speakers. Resetting every time you power up just eats into precious time that could be better utilised lazing on the couch!

After all the trials and tribulations were over, we finally settled down to choosing the winners. The Odyssey walked away with the

Value for Money prize, for a decent performance, reinforced by a killer price of just Rs 2,800. Deciding on the performance winner was much tougher. After hours of heated debate, we decided that the Creative Inspire 5.1 5700D deserved to win. The Creative Megaworks and the Artis X10 were way ahead in terms of raw power, but it was the clarity of the Creative 5700D that grabbed it the title.

